

End-of-Lease Bond-Back Checklist — South Australia

Protect your money — most bond disputes are avoidable with the right documentation.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal advice.

Section 1 — Understand How Your Bond Works

- ☐ ☐ **Know your bond is lodged with the Residential Tenancies Fund**, not held by your landlord or agent directly.
- ☐ ☐ **Know the lodgement deadlines that apply to whoever manages your tenancy** — bonds must generally be lodged within 2 weeks (self-managing landlords) or 4 weeks (registered agents) of receipt, which affects how quickly your bond is properly protected from the start of your tenancy.
- ☐ ☐ **Understand bond is not a general maintenance fund** — it can only be claimed against for unpaid rent, cleaning to restore the property (allowing for fair wear and tear), or damage beyond fair wear and tear.

Section 2 — Before You Move Out

- ☐ ☐ **Locate your original entry condition report** — your baseline for comparison.
- ☐ ☐ **Compare the property's current condition against that report**, room by room.
- ☐ ☐ **Clean thoroughly**, addressing anything genuinely beyond fair wear and tear.
- ☐ ☐ **Check every item on the original inventory** is present and in working order.
- ☐ ☐ **Settle any outstanding rent** before vacating.

Section 3 — At the Final Inspection

- ☐ ☐ **Attend the final inspection if you can**, comparing the property against the original condition report.
- ☐ ☐ **Take your own timestamped photos** of every room after cleaning, regardless of whether the agent attends.
- ☐ ☐ **Keep every receipt** — cleaning, repairs, pest control — as evidence.

Section 4 — Claiming Your Bond

- ☐ ☐ **Lodge your side of the bond claim** once you've vacated.
- ☐ ☐ **If both parties agree**, the bond is released according to the agreed split.
- ☐ ☐ **If there's a dispute**, either party can apply to the **South Australian Civil and Administrative Tribunal (SACAT)** for resolution.
- ☐ ☐ **Know about the evidence requirements introduced in the 2024 reforms**. Bond claims now face stricter evidence rules, designed to eliminate unreliable claims — meaning both you and your landlord need to substantiate claims with genuine documentation, not just assertions.

Section 5 — If There's a Dispute

- ☐ ☐ **Gather your evidence before applying to SACAT**: entry and exit condition reports, timestamped photos, receipts, and correspondence.
- ☐ ☐ **Know about internal review limits**. Following the 2024 reforms, a party generally cannot apply for internal review of a SACAT order requiring payment of money unless exceptional circumstances apply — this is designed to prevent delays in compensation and bond payments, so treat your SACAT hearing as your main opportunity to present your case thoroughly.
- ☐ ☐ **Apply promptly** if you disagree with an outcome, given the limited review pathway.

Quick Reference — SA Bond Process

ITEM	DETAIL
Bond lodgement deadline	2 weeks (self-managing landlord) / 4 weeks (agent)
Dispute resolution	SACAT (South Australian Civil and Administrative Tribunal)
Evidence requirements	Strengthened under 2024 reforms
Internal review of money orders	Limited to exceptional circumstances (since 2024)
Fair wear and tear	Cannot be charged against your bond

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